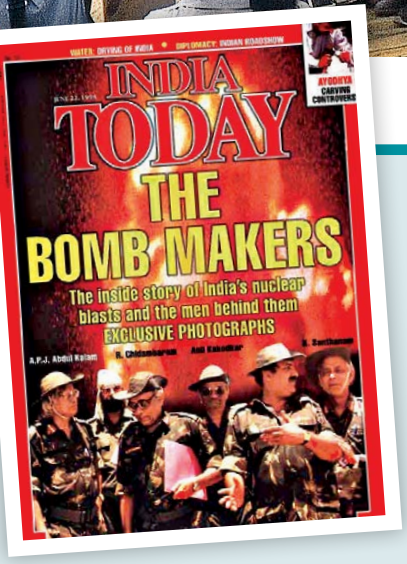
OPERATION SHAKTI

PM Vajpayee, defence minister George Fernandes, A.P.J. Kalam and other ministers and officials at the Pokhran blast site, May 1998



part of the extraordinary precaution the team had taken to prevent news of its frequent visits to the Pokhran range in Rajasthan from leaking out. With the range storming with army personnel, it made sense for scientists and engineers to don uniform so that they could move around without attracting attention. ❞

proved resilient (mostly because sanctions were enforced half-heartedly). More troubling were the repercussions closer to home for, within weeks, Pakistan responded with its own nuclear tests, leaving the whole South Asian neighbourhood jittery.

In the long term, though, it was now clear that India had a seat at the nuclear high table and nobody could push it off. Its refusal to sign the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) did create some tremors, but over time the firm stand and the country's record spoke for itself. The rehabilitation was complete with the Indo-US Civil Nuclear Agreement in 2008, an outcome few would have foreseen in 1998. ■

